

Background

Matt Navaro, CEO of Stanley 1913, leans back in his chair as he and his board members review the performance of the company in the past quarter. During the meeting, he opens up a larger discussion to the board about how each member visualizes the growth trajectory of the firm. With a diverse mix on the board, ideas of international expansion, new product segment introduction, and product line diversification are thrown around. As Matt considers each of these, he decides it would be worth consulting his CFO, Stephen Thate, on the financial health of the company and whether there is room in the budget for a new venture.

As he adjourns the meeting and the sounds of pens clicking, laptops closing, and chairs swiveling fill the room, he directs his secretary to compile a list of reputable consulting firms that can advise him on making this decision. Standing in the room alone, he wonders whether this new direction is the right move for Stanley 1913.

Stanley 1913's History

Stanley 1913's revolution in the market started when William Stanley Jr. invented the first all-steel insulated vacuum bottle in 1913¹. With a background in electrical engineering, William put his name on the map by inventing the first AC transformer system, showing how electrical power could be safe, marketable, and cost-efficient². One day, when looking for a way to keep his coffee warm all day, he combined an all-steel construction and a double-layered wall and patented the core of the Stanley 1913 thermos (Exhibit A), which was much more effective than the glass competitors at the time².

Due to its durability, the Stanley 1913 became the ideal solution for people who needed coffee or any other hot drink to last all day, no matter what. Naturally, they began to target blue-collar workers in construction and work sites, and outdoor fanatics who enjoyed hiking, mountaineering, camping, and cross-country activities. All of whom revelled at the cup for its sleek construction and functional nature³.

In 2017 however, blogger Ashlee LeSueur, co-founder of 'The Buy Guide', discovered the 40-ounce Stanley Quencher. Falling in love with its features, she gifted them to her co-founders, Linley Hutchinson and Taylor Cannon, who also proceeded to rave over the product³. One day, hearing rumors that the quencher would be discontinued, they reached out to Stanley 1913, who suggested that they place a wholesale order of a minimum of 10,000 units, as the company did not have any formalized affiliate marketing programs at the time³. Taking the risk, the founders purchased the cups, and within the first few days, all 10,000 cups had been sold.

The main customers of The Buy Guide were overwhelmingly female, and this revelation showed Stanley 1913 that the product had significant potential as a daily-use item, one that would be functional for anyone and anything, and constructed in a way that could last a lifetime³.

Since then, the company has pivoted to expanding its marketing efforts toward everyday use cases and demographics, alongside that, building a strong portfolio of complementary products, aiming to provide that same functionality that the original Quencher did to all aspects of a person's life.

Core Product Offerings

In the decades following the original Stanley 1913 thermos' invention, Stanley 1913 has gone on to develop many additional products.

Drinkware

Stanley 1913 continues to carry its heritage product, now called the *Classic Legendary Bottle*, in a similar style to the one William Stanley Jr. invented over 100 years ago, and its viral Quencher. Beyond these, they've created many other water bottles, such as the IceFlow™, claiming to keep iced drinks cold for days on end, as well as The Wellspring, a push-button flip-top bottle allowing easy and convenient sipping access, alongside others.

The company also has products specializing in warm drinks, such as their various types of mugs, perfect for coffee and tea when out camping or commuting through the airport. Lastly, Stanley 1913 has expanded into bar products, featuring a variety of flasks, beer glasses, wine tumblers, and cocktail sets perfect for bars, hobbyists, and the everyday enthusiast alike.

Foodware

Built upon its foundation of keeping products cool or warm, Stanley 1913 has created a line specializing in personal-use foodware products, such as lunch boxes, coolers, bowls, and bags. Additionally, larger and more durable versions targeting outdoor or pro-use exist, including catering-ready pans, water jugs, kettles, hot crocks, or a portable multi-piece cookset for camping.

Accessories

The last main product is their accessories, meant to add flair or utility to any Stanley 1913 product. Ranging from boots and straw covers, to straps, keychains, lids, and other novelty items, users have the option to personalize their Stanley cup however they'd like, making no two Stanleys look alike.

2020-2023: Stanley's Big Break

Stanley 1913's signature Quencher tumbler, first launched in 2016, had initially garnered little attention and was near the brink of discontinuation. However, after its exposure in 'The Buy Guide', Stanley 1913 was exposed to a new target market and slowly started shifting to this new demographic. The popularity of the Quencher took off exponentially after a video went viral on TikTok⁴. The video showcased the durability of the tumbler, which remained unscathed after a car fire incident (Exhibit B)⁵. This video helped Stanley 1913 develop an authentic relationship with its target customers through the medium of user-generated content.

In the aftermath of this incident, Stanley 1913 completely molded its marketing strategy to a combination of collaborations, influencer endorsements, and a powerful TikTok presence to capitalize on the spotlight⁶. At the same time, Stanley 1913 slowly transitioned its brand from solely a "utilitarian item to a chic must-have." The product design also helped this branding shift due to its functionality aspects, such as the ability to fit in car cup holders and a built-in straw, making it ideal for fast-paced and style-driven lifestyles⁶.

Market Presence

Stanley 1913 serves many of the world's major markets primarily through two channels: In-person presence through authorized dealers and other retail stores, or e-commerce, whether through their own website or certified e-commerce partners.

The Americas

In their home market of North America, Stanley 1913 holds a major physical and digital presence. In the United States, many large grocery chains, outdoor sporting brands, or retail brands carry their products, such as Walmart, Whole Foods, Lowe's, etc, meaning their products are in tens of thousands of stores across the U.S. As a result, their brand is well situated in every state, major city, and urban area, making them a staple sight for many American customers.

Canada is also a large market for Stanley 1913, with the brand having significant physical presence in many major cities like Montreal, Edmonton, and Vancouver, primarily in outdoor equipment or apparel stores like Boathouse, Bass Pro Shops, and MEC. The brand also maintains a strong digital presence through its own website as well as key online distributors such as Amazon.

In Latin America, the brand has a mix of e-commerce and physical store presence, with store presence in El Salvador through the retail chain Hot N Cold⁷. E-commerce

distribution is provided through partners such as Mercado Libre and the Brazilian beauty brand MKPBR⁸. Additionally, Brazil is one of Stanley 1913's two major manufacturers for its products⁹, and the brand has previously collaborated with key Latin American personalities such as world famous soccer player, Lionel Messi (Exhibit C), to create special digital exclusive collaborations of its key products¹⁰.

Europe

In the EU, Stanley 1913 balances both physical and digital presence, with select retailers serving key markets and a dedicated Stanley 1913 EU website for the region. For example, in the UK, one of their largest European markets, the brand is partnered with Urban Outfitters to provide most of its physical distribution of products within the country. This is seen in other markets such as France, their second largest European market, being served by the sports retailer Ekosport, and other countries having their own select partnerships and distribution partners according to Stanley 1913's official store locator.

Asia & Oceania

In Asia, Stanley 1913 has a more sparse physical distribution strategy, having a mix of their own branded stores and select partners. Products can be found in concentrated, high-traction shopping areas in key cities such as Manila, Tokyo, and Bangkok. In some regions, they have created partnerships with large retailers for in-store and online distribution, such as with JD Sports in Singapore¹¹, but they have also shown instances of piloting their own branded stores, such as in The Gardens Mall in Malaysia, where the brand created its own pop-up store inside the mall¹².

E-Commerce is also strong in Asia, with many large online retailers like Shopee, Lazada, and Alibaba carrying Stanley 1913 products, though the brand maintains some regionally specific websites, such as Indonesia's own Stanley 1913 website. The region is also home to the brand's other large manufacturing operation, located in China, where a significant majority of its products are manufactured.

Lastly, the brand is present in Oceania in both Australia and New Zealand, with a regional website existing for Stanley 1913 Australia and products available to purchase in-store in New South Wales or Auckland through select retail partners.

Industry Overview

The food and beverage storage container market is a globally connected market, where raw material prices, international supply chain, economies of scale, and brand visibility dictate success in the market. The market consists of solutions, including but not limited to jars, cups, mugs, boxes, containers, lunchboxes, and bags.

Size & Growth

According to Data Bridge Market Research, the global food storage container market was valued at approximately \$173.45B (Exhibit D), with a projected CAGR of 4.6% from 2025 to 2032, reaching a market size of almost a quarter of a trillion dollars by 2032¹³. The market can be considered fragmented, with a variety of large multinational competitors such as Clorox, LocknLock, Yeti, and Tupperware, who may operate both primarily and secondarily in this market.

Asia Pacific (APAC) dominates the market with a 36.76% market share as a result of having significant global manufacturing presence and also a large proportion of the global population residing in the region¹³. However, many regions are experiencing stronger growth as the industry begins to shift toward new materials, aesthetics, function, and sustainability.

Trends

In line with many other industries, sustainability is slowly becoming a key deciding factor for consumers, as single-use plastic and non-biodegradable materials are being replaced by stainless steel and glass¹⁴. However, plastic remains the largest share of the market, holding almost 50% of all food storage sales due to its ease of manufacturing, low cost, and existing integration into many consumer lifestyles¹⁴.

Convenience is also becoming another important aspect for consumers, as urban lifestyles and fast-paced work and life scenarios require individuals to search for solutions for quick meals, whether through meal kits, ready-to-eat meals, or meal preparation. As a result, the search for reusable, portable, and reheatable food storage solutions is on the rise¹³.

Finally, innovations in food storage are disrupting the industry. Rather than simply innovating on the material, they bring with them unique technologies aiming at helping to improve freshness, reduce moisture, and enhance portability¹⁴. Companies manufacturing such products are able to bring with them higher prices, stronger margins, as well as increased brand loyalty and equity.

Industry Profitability

The food storage industry is consistently profitable, with many large conglomerates leveraging economies of scale to achieve net income margins in the double-digit percentages (Exhibit E). The biggest drivers of cost are materials and SG&A, which remain high as a result of dealing with complex international logistics, manufacturing, and having large global workforces. Additionally, many players in the

industry own multiple different brands and have different product lines, allowing them to expand into different segments and ensure long term financial stability.

Competitive Landscape

Stanley 1913 primarily competes in the reusable food and beverage containers market, with a recent focus on lifestyle and social media marketing to reach its target audience. Within its industry, Stanley 1913 has a few direct and indirect competitors with which it competes on parameters such as market share, pricing comparisons, product offerings, and marketing strategies.

Direct competitors

In terms of direct competitors, Stanley 1913 competes alongside firms like Yeti, HydroFlask, Owala, and SimpleModern (Exhibit F). While each of these companies offer their own version of food and/or beverage containers, they each have unique value propositions. HydroFlask and Yeti have built a reputation for their insulation capabilities, with Yeti also offering clear lids that allow tracking for drink levels. On the other hand, Owala focuses on ergonomic design, prioritizing product development for practicality and ease-of-use, alongside offering fun color combinations¹⁵. Stanley 1913 also has to compete with Simple Modern and Owala on the grounds of offering lower pricing, as they strike “a balance between affordability and performance¹⁵.”

Indirect competitors

In the indirect competitor space, Stanley 1913 competes with food container companies like Thermos and Snapware. Thermos offers the Stainless King Food Jar, which retails at a “fraction of the price” of the Stanley 1913 containers, but offers a dependable way of keeping food hot or cold for hours with its insulation capabilities¹⁶. With Snapware, they lead the glass food storage container market by offering high functionality and convenience with features such as being made of “high-quality borosilicate glass, oven-safe, microwave-safe, dishwasher-safe, and freezer-safe¹⁷.”

Going Global

Given the ever-changing nature of consumer behavior, Stanley 1913 needs to consider different aspects of the buyer decision-making process to optimize its strategy for the future.

The first consideration in this process is for Stanley 1913 to define its target market for each of its product offerings. This step is crucial, as it allows the brand to build

awareness of the different purchasing characteristics, including, but not limited to, paying capacity, product design, and lifestyle focus.

The next consideration for Stanley 1913 is a growing global focus on sustainability and ethical production. In a recent study conducted by McKinsey and Co., it was noted that 60% of respondents indicated that they would pay more for a product with sustainable packaging, and 78% of U.S. consumers say that a “sustainable lifestyle is important for them¹⁸.”

The third consideration for Stanley 1913 is the growing younger generation's focus on the 'less is more' mentality, which has led to a quantifiable adoption of the 'minimalist' culture. In an article by The Medium, the authors elaborate on how the widespread adoption of minimalism among gen z and millennial consumers is making companies rethink their products and prioritize “quality over quantity¹⁹.”

Bearing these key considerations in mind, it is important to contextualize them with Stanley 1913's potential for growth. As the brand pursues its long term growth objectives, it is important to identify which markets align with these sentiments. Key barriers to a product offering being a great success in a pre-existing market, but not seeing success in a new market, could include things such as the variable paying capacity of the consumers or culture differences. The liability of foreignness rests completely on Stanley 1913's shoulders, and the burden of acceptance goes beyond traditional cultural and value alignment barriers, but also into localized industry price ranges, established competitors, healthy operating margins, and brand positioning.

Key Concerns

To achieve success in an ever changing environment, while working around Stanley 1913's existing brand success, a few key issues become necessary to consider while making strategic decisions moving forward.

Overreliance on a Singular Product

With authentic UGC marketing and incredible customer resonance, the Quencher tumbler has been one of the most commercially successful and well-loved products in recent years. While this product retains relevance and a strong hold in the market, it is key to ensure that it is not restricting its brand recognition and product offering resonance with the customers. Continuing the tradition of innovation that Stanley 1913 was founded on, the company needs to consider whether it would like to expand, change, or pivot its current product portfolio to break out of the single “hero” product loop. Additionally, this will prove to be an important consideration from the

revenue perspective to ensure that sales do not drastically decline and severely impact cash flows as the product reaches the mature stage of its product life cycle.

Tariffs and Supply Chain Constraints

As an American company that operates internationally, Stanley 1913 must track developments in foreign relations, specifically with regard to tariffs and potential supply chain constraints. In the present uncertain times, the company needs to be thorough in its consideration of whether it enters an international market and what the product landing costs will look like in that market, given foreign affairs. Another constraint that comes with international expansion is establishing strong and optimized supply chain routes. Given trade restrictions and production expectations from consumers, it is important for Stanley 1913 to choose its international supply chain relationships carefully.

Maintaining Relevance

The final concern for Stanley 1913 is maintaining relevance with evolving market and consumer dynamics. While the company found its pivot through a viral TikTok video and have since built trust with younger consumers, the company must look beyond the hype cycle and into long-term sustenance of brand reputation and sales. With a new and younger customer base from social media, Stanley 1913 will have to recast its target market with both product offerings and marketing geared towards its full consumer base that may lie on a greater spectrum of ages and lifestyles.

Conclusion

As Matt wraps up his meeting with his head of strategy, a familiar ring fills the room as an email pops up in his inbox. Opening it, he finds multiple attached pitch decks from consulting firms outlining their value proposition for Stanley 1913. Looking forward, a new wave of excitement flows over him. A new version of Stanley 1913 is on its way, one that will not only continue to honor its current and original legacy but also bring something new and exciting for the world to see.

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Appendix

Exhibit A: Original Stanley 1913 thermos next to the Stanley 1913 Classic Legendary Vacuum Insulated Bottle



Source: [Stanley1913.com](https://stanley1913.com). Old Stanley vs. New Stanley: What's Really Changed In The Unbreakable Bottle?

Exhibit B: Viral car incident TikTok featuring the Stanley 1913 Quencher



Source: [@danimarielettering](https://tiktok.com)

Exhibit C: Stanley 1913 collaboration with Lionel Messi



Source: The Hollywood Reporter, *Lionel Messi and Stanley Co-Design Their Second Limited-Edition Drinkware Capsule*

Exhibit D: Food storage container industry growth (2025-2032)



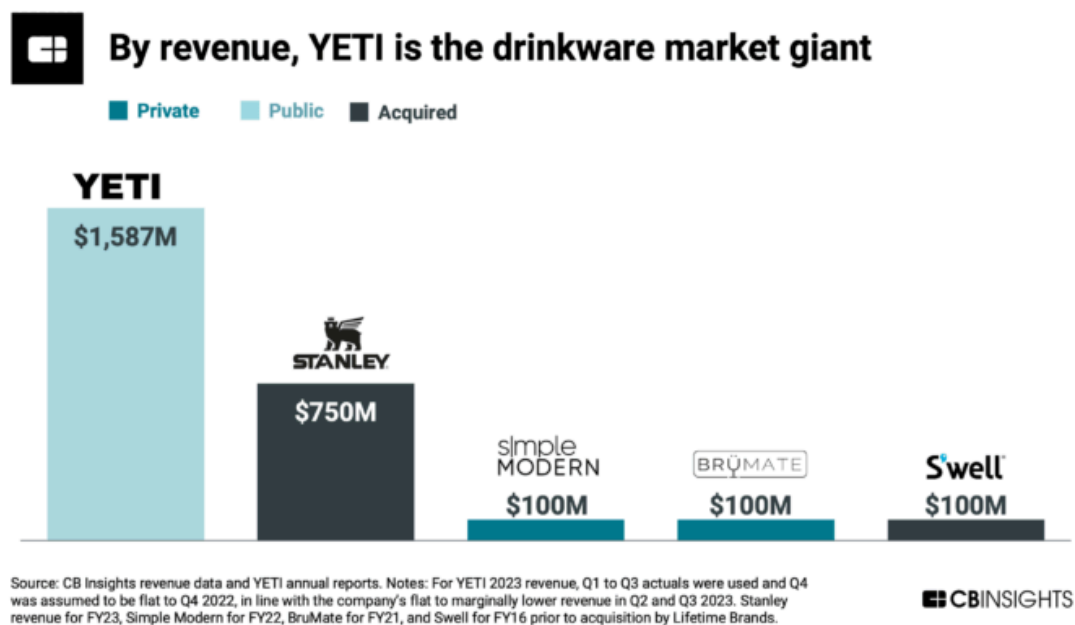
Source: Databridge Market Research 2025 Report

Exhibit E: Public comparable competitors' financial metrics

Publicly Traded Comparables				
Firm	Revenue	Gross Margin (%)	EBIT Margin (%)	Net Income
Clorox	\$7,104.0MM	45.22%	15.17%	\$824.0MM
Yeti Holdings	\$1,829.8MM	58.11%	12.72%	\$175.7MM
Helen of Troy	\$1,907.7MM	47.93%	4.81%	\$123.8MM
Sealed Air	\$5,359.8MM	29.79%	13.54%	\$505.5MM

The authors of this case have compiled the information from various publicly available financial sources to create this exhibit.
Source: SEC Edgar, Various 10k Filings for FY25 and FY26

Exhibit F: Market share by competitor



Source: CBInsights 2024 Report